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It Takes Less Money Than You Think

I was sitting in the transit lounge of Heathrow Airport in London when the notion of very early retirement first came to me. I was on the way home from a business trip to Europe, dozing off in my chair, when I overheard two guys talking about someone.

"He did a couple of dope-smuggling deals in Mexico," one of them said. "Very big. But it was risky, so he got out and bought real estate in San Diego County. He's retired now—lives on a ranch down there, breeding horses and hunting."

There I was, tired, successful, lonesome for my wife, Vicki, peeking out the corner of my eye at two guys in designer jeans and lizard-skin cowboy boots. They had Halliburton cases at their sides and smoked cigarettes I didn't recognize. They were talking about someone my age who had retired.

I wasn't a drug dealer, just a certified public accountant. I was 33 years old, a partner in a major accounting firm. Ahead lay a future of big challenges and big money. But I began toying with the notion that if I could come up with a way to live off what I already had, I'd never have to work